at last alarm bells began to ring. Lord Curzon, the Viceroy, heard of this and refused to go on a lion hunt in Gir during his state visit to Junagarh in November 1900. The Nawabs of Junagarh, with the support of the colonial government, now became the guardians of the endangered species for the next half-century. The Gir forest was protected and hunting strictly regulated. Only the most senior British officials and Indian princes were allowed the privilege. In fact, there is a lot of correspondence to show that the Nawabs had to refuse permission to many princes and British officials who wanted to hunt in Gir. It must have been diplomatically difficult but, to their credit, the Nawabs stood their ground. Gir is still the only place where the Asiatic lion survives in the wild with a count of 411 in 2010. The Indian cheetah was not so lucky. The last documented sighting of the Indian cheetah was in Madhya Pradesh in 1947, the same year that India became independent. [22]

A NEW NEW DELHI

After the sack of 1858, Delhi dwindled to being a mere district headquarters in Punjab province. The census of 1881 showed that its urban population had dwindled to 173,393. [23] The Mughal-era city of Shahjehanabad was still the main urban hub, with European troops based inside the Red Fort and Indian troops stationed in Daryagunj. The railways had connected the city to Lahore in the west and to Calcutta in the east. To the north of the walled city, the British had built a Civil Lines with large bungalows and gardens. With its numerous historical buildings, late-nineteenth-century Delhi would have been picturesque but, compared to Bombay, Calcutta or Madras, it was a backwater. And so it remained till 1911.

Meanwhile, tiny cracks were appearing in the foundations of the British Raj. Yet again, the vagaries of nature were partly responsible for this. From 1874, India suffered a series of severe droughts. At first Bengal and Bihar were affected, but the Viceroy Lord Northbrook and famine commissioner Sir Richard Temple dealt with it reasonably competently by importing rice from Burma. Instead of congratulating them, however, British Prime